

EG Daily Brief: Ian Bremmer on Iran, AI risk, and Graham's death

送信者: EG Daily Brief 受信日時: 2026-07-13 21:33

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13 Jul 2026 08:24 EDT

Daily Brief: Ian Bremmer on Iran, AI risk, and Graham's death

Ian Bremmer on Iran | Trump's election moves | El Niño's Latin America fallout | El Niño's ASEAN fallout
| Mexico-US ties | Upcoming conference calls | EG in depth

summary

- * Ian Bremmer assesses Iran's upper hand in the Strait of Hormuz, a looming regulatory environment for artificial intelligence, and the death of Senator Lindsey Graham.
- * President Donald Trump's dismissal of Election Assistance Commission commissioners may foreshadow moves that would tilt the 2028 electoral playing field.
- * In Latin America, Ecuador and Venezuela bear El Niño's sharpest political costs, while in ASEAN, the Philippines and Indonesia face its highest food security and economic risks.
- * Mexico's legal offensive against ICE—filing complaints over 17 nationals' deaths in custody—escalates an already strained bilateral relationship with Washington.
- * Countries, regions, and sectors covered include the US, Argentina, Bolivia, Brazil, Ecuador, Indonesia, Latin America, the Philippines, Mexico, and Venezuela.

the top line

Ian Bremmer on Iran, AI, and US politics

- * Iran last week and this past weekend targeted a number of ships sailing through the Strait of Hormuz... leading the US president to retaliate with the most significant steps since ending the blockade: revoking sanctions waivers against Iran, authorizing two nights of military strikes... and declaring the US-Iran ceasefire and preliminary deal "over." The Gulf states are gaining an upper hand in the de facto outcome of strait transit... Iran sees little downside from lashing out militarily to improve their position.
- * Artificial intelligence is another matter. It's too powerful, too fast moving... driven by humans who mostly don't understand the implications of what they're developing... a far more significant regulatory environment is coming. Likely after crisis as opposed to preemptively.
- * On the sudden passing of Lindsey Graham: Behind the scenes, he remained a voice of restraint on a number of Trump's more unilateralist foreign policies... I'm sorry he never found peace.

For more of Ian's insights on the NATO summit, China and more, read the EG Update .

US—Watch for moves against the Federal Election Commission

- * Watch for moves against Federal Election Commission (FEC). Trump's dismissal of all commissioners on the Election Assistance Commission (EAC) is mostly a nothingburger—but could be a worrying sign for election integrity if it presages action against partisan balance on the commission, on the grounds that the Supreme Court's ruling last month allows its commissioners to be fired at will.
- * Any moves against partisan balance at the FEC, which regulates federal campaign finance law, would be a much bigger deal. The FEC currently has two Democratic commissioners, with two Republican nominations pending. With six slots total, the agency requires a four-commissioner quorum to operate.
- * If Trump moved to appoint four Republicans to the board, it would turn the FEC into a partisan agency that could selectively enforce campaign finance law against Democrats and rewrite regulations to benefit Republicans. That would structurally tilt the electoral playing field away from Democrats ahead of the 2028 presidential election.
- * Read more here . Reach out to discuss: unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net .

Latin America—El Niño's political costs will likely hit Andean governments hardest

- * Latin America faces uneven El Niño exposure, with the Andean region and Central America most at risk given dependence on hydroelectricity and agriculture—vulnerabilities compounded by inflation resulting from the Iran conflict.
- * Political repercussions will be most pronounced in Ecuador, where renewed blackouts would pressure the government into costly relief measures ahead of November's midterms, and in Venezuela, where drought complicates post-earthquake reconstruction, while risking honeymoon periods in Colombia and Peru.
- * A record soy harvest in Argentina will boost President Javier Milei ahead of 2027, while the impact on Brazil is mixed—potential gains in the south offset by drought and wildfires in the northeast—though price effects are unlikely before the October election.
- * Read more here . Reach out to discuss: latinamerica@eurasiagroup.net .

Philippines and Indonesia face highest El Niño risks in region

- * The Philippines and Indonesia face the greatest El Niño-driven food security and economic risks in Southeast Asia, one of the regions expected to be most adversely affected by the looming weather pattern.
- * Though regional and global food supply disruption would exacerbate high inflation and increase fiscal pressure, political risks from El Niño are fairly limited.
- * El Niño threatens to disrupt ASEAN's output of major agricultural exports including rice, palm oil, and robusta coffee—though export bans are unlikely barring extreme scenarios, with resource-nationalist

Indonesia the likeliest exception.

* Read more here . Reach out to discuss: southeastasia@eurasiagroup.net .

Mexico, US—Mexico's legal offensive against ICE risks more direct clash with Washington

* Foreign Minister Roberto Velasco announced that the administration will file criminal complaints against Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) agents and civil actions against companies operating ICE detention centers after 17 Mexican nationals died in custody or during enforcement operations. President Claudia Sheinbaum is shifting from diplomatic protest to direct legal action in the US, a step that raises the stakes in an already tense bilateral relationship.

* Targeting private contractors and state prosecutors gives Sheinbaum political cover domestically, but complaints directed at the Department of Justice could be read in Washington as a direct challenge to Trump's immigration policy.

* These actions risk further straining the bilateral relationship as Washington continues to pressure Sheinbaum on security and trade. However, the president's reluctance to process and extradite Sinaloa Governor Ruben Rocha and his allies will remain the main source of contention in the coming weeks.

* Read more here . Reach out to discuss: mexico@eurasiagroup.net .

Upcoming conference calls

* 13 July 9:00 PM ET—Iran war & ceasefire outlook. Register here .

* 14 July 8:30 AM ET—EU energy outlook: Electricity costs will fall sharply by 2030. Register here .

* 15 July 10:00 AM ET—China's growing economic coercion toolkit. Register here .

* 15 July 11:00 AM ET—Brazil update: the fight against organized crime. Register here .

* 21 July 9:00 PM ET—Claude Mythos: cyber power, competition & global risk. Register here .

eg in depth

Mexico—Trade and investment diversification efforts are meant to complement US ties. Faced with fiscal constraints and limited public resources, Sheinbaum's administration is seeking new sources of investment and financing for its Plan Mexico infrastructure initiative through trade agreements that unlock FDI and technology transfers. The recent European Parliament approval of the modernized EU-Mexico agreement and the decision to remain in the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP) are the latest steps to diversify investment and financing sources. Persistent financing gaps will keep pushing the administration toward blended structures, private capital, and multilateral support to sustain priority projects, but domestic bottlenecks will limit how much diversification translates into realized investment. Read more here . Reach out to discuss: mexico@eurasiagroup.net .

Venezuela—New oil regulations advance liberalization efforts. Interim President Delcy Rodriguez signed the regulations implementing Venezuela's January Hydrocarbons Law reform. The long-delayed regulations seek to attract investment into the oil and gas sector, though leave a high degree of executive discretion. The framework improves fiscal predictability by setting combined royalty and hydrocarbons tax rates by project type, but does not address structural constraints. Uncertainties remain around dispute resolution and executive discretion in implementation. Separately, on 9 July, the IMF confirmed it is working with Venezuelan authorities to facilitate access to \$350 million to support earthquake-related humanitarian needs. Read more here . Reach out to discuss: latinamerica@eurasiagroup.net .

Upcoming Events:

- * 14 July: Events: Fed Chair Kevin Warsh testifies before the House Financial Services Committee. Data: China trade, US CPI.
- * 15 July: Events: Fed Chair Kevin Warsh testifies before the Senate Banking Committee. Data: China GDP, retail sales, industrial production, fixed assets investment, Eurozone industrial production, US PPI. Central banks: Canada rate decision, Fed Beige Book.
- * 16 July: Data: UK industrial production, trade balance, US retail sales. Central banks: South Korea rate decision.
- * 17 July: Events: The World Artificial Intelligence Conference is held in Shanghai through 20 July. Data: Eurozone CPI, US housing starts, University of Michigan consumer sentiment, industrial production.

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closing quip

I went from, 'OK, he's president, to 'How can I get to be in his orbit?' to 'How can I get to have a say in what's going to happen today, tomorrow, and next week?'"—Lindsey Graham, who died on 11 July, told the New York Times in 2019, referring to Trump.

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Explanation of Political Trajectories (ie, "Trajectories")

Eurasia Group's (EG) Political Trajectories are indicators of the net impact of political factors on the macro business environment in a country over specific timeframes. For each country, two Trajectories are provided, a short-term (6 months) and a long term assessment (24 months). Trajectories are assigned by Eurasia Group's country analysts through a structured qualitative process. Each Trajectory represents a net assessment, indicating how political changes in a country impact the macro business environment, defined as the economic and investment climate in the country. Once initiated,

Trajectories are updated both periodically and as events warrant. Trajectories may be suspended from time to time if there is no active analyst opinion or analyst coverage, but the opinion or coverage is expected to resume. Trajectories can be:

Positive: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a positive impact on the macro business environment

Neutral: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a neutral or negligible impact on the macro business environment

Negative: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a negative impact on the macro business environment

Disclaimers: Trajectories are solely for informational purposes and should not be relied upon as investment advice. Trajectories do not indicate asset price movements, and have no value in forecasting market prices. Trajectories are based on data and analysis we deem to be reliable; they are not guaranteed as to accuracy or completeness. The Trajectories indicate the political outlook in a single country, over time. Trajectories do not address sector-specific or city/regional political risks that are often different than the country-level outlook. Trajectories represent an analyst's net qualitative assessment of a country's political outlook. EG sales, analytic staff and products may provide analysis reflecting different opinions than those expressed by the Trajectories.

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